imperial has been applied to ruling elites from regional power centres – including Israel, Turkey, Indonesia and Taiwan – which have also served the military, extractive and legitimating interests of imperialism. However, this status needs regular revisiting especially because others in a similar role (e.g. Iran before 1979, Argentina before 1982) found the posture to be profoundly contradictory. Fred Halliday (1979:283) advocated the following concept of sub-imperialism, '(a) a continuing if partial strategic subordination to US imperialism on the one hand, and (b) an autonomous regional role on the other.' The volatility intrinsic in this location reflects not the strength but rather the fragility of Washington's agenda, namely, a 'doctrine designed to create a structure of sub-imperial powers', as Joseph Gerson and Bruce Birchard (1991) explained.

The term sub-imperialism has had other euphemisms, including the 'semi-periphery' coined by Immanuel Wallerstein (1974, 1997), which continues to be used by world systems analysts. Chris Chase-Dunn (2013) remarks 'that the main function of having a stratum in the middle is to somewhat depolarise the larger system analogously to a large middle class within a national society'. Alternatively, a 'secondary imperialist' role for Australia and Canada reflects a very different relationship to imperialism in these countries (Albo and Klaasen 2013). In the same spirit, the word 'sub-empire' refers 'to a lower-level empire that is dependent on an empire at a higher level in the imperialist hierarchy', according to Chen Kuan-Hsing (2013:18).

These are ideas generally favoured by left critics of imperialism. In contrast, the concept 'middle power' is so nebulous and non-threatening that its use by mainstream political scientists continues to depoliticise the art of global geopolitics (Jordaan 2003). Finally, for historians (whether radical or mainstream), the age of imperialism was the era *prior* to World War I, replete with colonial relations and the scramble for parts of the world without strong states, especially in Africa, so the concept of sub-imperial powers – especially the British colonies that came to make up South Africa in 1910 – has occasionally been invoked in this context.

Imperialism, capitalist crisis, super-exploitation and regional hegemony

The semantic differences are not important, not when compared to at least four core, lasting relations of sub-imperialism: to imperialism, to capitalist crisis tendencies, to regional hegemony and to super-exploitative processes of accumulation.

First, to define sub-imperialism properly implies a coherent definition of the systemic processes of imperialism within which it operates. There are a variety of ways to understand imperialism, but the most durable appears to be the